

Trophy

Alex Baker Survives a Ten

John Patterson outplayed him over two of the four rounds and still finished eight adrift.

Alex Baker began the final round at PGA Catalunya's Stadium Course with a 12-point cushion in the TEG 18 Trophy. He finished with eight. That was still more than enough, which is the kindest sentence available about what happened in between.

The margin shrank because the round was a mess. He dropped seven shots across holes 9 to 11: a triple bogey at the 9th, the hardest hole on the course, then double bogeys at the 10th and 11th. Then came the 14th. He took a sextuple bogey 10 there, a blank on the card, and followed it with a quadruple bogey 8 at the 17th, also blank. Two holes, no points, no apparent concern. A man with a

lead can afford to be generous. He was extremely generous.

John Patterson was the only man close enough to matter, and he made his move early: nine Stableford points across holes 4 to 6, three apiece at the 4th, 5th and 6th. It was a fine, purposeful piece of golf. It was not enough to catch Alex Baker.

The gross reckoning was less forgiving. Second after round one, he finished fifth and last in the TEG 18 Green Jacket, won by Gregg Williams. He won the thing he was chasing and came last in the thing he was not. The Trophy does not ask for an explanation.

AT A GLANCE
Trophy Winner Alex Baker
Green Jacket Gregg Williams
Wooden Spoon Jon Baker

Round Stableford
GW 44 JP 42 AB 38 DM 38 JB 29
Round Gross
GW +12 DM +18 JP +22 JB +25 AB +36

After R4 • Trophy
AB 169 JP 161 GW 160 DM 149 JB 126
After R4 • Green Jacket
GW +66 DM +80 JB +92 JP +95 AB +124

Green Jacket | Gregg Williams

Forty-Four Points and a Course Best

Williams's 84 gross is his lowest score in seven visits to the Stadium, and his third-best gross round in 67 TEG rounds.

Gregg Williams finished the tournament at the Stadium Course with 44 Stableford points and an 84 gross. It was the best round of the day on both counts. Six points clear of the field of five, six shots better than anyone else's gross. The 84 was also his best score in eight visits to the Stadium, one better than the 85 he had carried as his course

mark. Eight attempts to move a number by one. He got there in the end.

The scoring came in clusters. He birdied the 5th and parred the 6th. Then he took nine points from holes 8 to 10: a par at the short 8th, a bogey at the 9th, the hardest hole on the course, which still returned three points, and a par at the 10th.

It settled the TEG 18 Green Jacket, which he had led going into the round and now leads by 14. It also dragged him back into the TEG 18 Trophy picture. Having trailed by as many as 15 points at one stage, he finished nine behind Alex Baker. Alex Baker keeps the Trophy lead, and the last word belonged to the golf course.

Wooden Spoon | Jon Baker

Five Straight Doubles Settle the Spoon

The birdie at the 13th ended a run of twelve holes without a par, by which point the arithmetic had long since stopped mattering.

Jon Baker arrived at the Stadium Course already holding the TEG 18 Wooden Spoon. The final round did nothing to loosen his grip. His lead over the next man went from 14 shots to 23.

The damage came in one unbroken stretch. From the 7th through the 11th he made five double bogeys in a row: a seven at the par-5 7th, fives at the 8th and 11th, sixes at the 9th and 10th. Ten shots dropped across five holes. One Stableford point apiece, collected with the grim regularity of a man signing for parcels he never ordered. The 9th, at stroke index 1, is the hardest hole on the course. The 7th and 11th are among the easiest. He treated them all exactly the same.

It was part of something longer. From the 2nd to the 12th, every single hole was a bogey or worse. Eleven holes without relief. The bleeding stopped at the 13th, where he made a birdie three, his first hole under par in eleven. It arrived far too late to mean anything and he took it anyway.

Stadium Course

Nobody Escapes Fourteen Through Seventeen

Spain's premier championship course saved its teeth for the last hour of TEG 18.

The closing stretch at the Stadium Course did most of the damage on Tuesday afternoon. David Mullin played holes 14 to 17 in nine over par. A double bogey at the 14th, a triple bogey 8 at the 15th, then further doubles at the 16th and 17th. Four holes, not one net par among them, three Stableford points salvaged from the wreckage. The 15th, which cost him three shots, is the easiest hole on the course by stroke index. It is not clear he was told.

John Patterson's version started worse. He took 7 at the 14th and another 7 at the 15th, three over and two over respectively. A bogey at the 16th steadied things, in the sense that a bogey can be described as steadying. Then he birdied the 17th and ended a run of holes at bogey or worse. That single birdie was worth five Stableford points. Mullin took three from the entire four-hole sequence.

Records & Personal Bests

Notable achievements: TEG 18, Round 4